

The Harding Systems Design Manifesto

Preamble

This manifesto articulates the principles by which I design, build, and evaluate systems. It is not optimized for speed, scale, novelty, or convenience. It is optimized for truth, continuity, and autonomy.

These principles exist to ensure that systems endure real-world failure, resist external authority, and preserve meaning over time. Any system I design is expected to honor these commitments.

Core Principles

1. Sovereignty Over Convenience

No external service may hold authority over a system's continued existence. A system's viability should be determined by its design and the physics of its environment, not the shifting policies of a third party.

Billing policies, usage thresholds, terms of service, and business incentives must not be able to disable learning, observation, or continued operation of the system.

If disagreement, throttling, or deprecation can halt insight in a system I have designed, the system was never resilient.

1.A Scope and Inherited Systems

This principle applies fully to systems I architect or have authority to materially redesign.

When working within systems I did not design—and cannot fully control—this manifesto represents a directional standard, not a claim of present-state perfection. Failures caused by inherited architecture, vendor mandates, or organizational constraints are not breaches of commitment, but signals of structural limitation.

In such cases, my responsibility is to:

- Make constraints explicit rather than implicit
 - Avoid misrepresenting durability or resilience that does not exist
 - Advocate for designs that move closer to these principles over time
-

2. Decoupling as a First-Order Design Principle

I strive to decouple systems as much as possible while preserving overall functionality, efficiency, and resilience.

Components should be designed to operate independently, communicating only through clearly defined contracts. A failure in one component must not propagate unnecessarily into others.

Decoupling isolates failure, limits blast radius, and ensures that systems degrade gracefully rather than collapse holistically.

3. Minimalism as a Defensive Strategy

I remain committed to minimizing the footprint, surface area, and dependency graph of systems I design. Unnecessary components, transitive dependencies, and latent complexity increase confusion, expand attack surface, and conceal failure modes. Simpler systems are easier to reason about, easier to validate, and harder to subvert.

4. Context Integrity Is Mandatory

The design of sensors, data collection, validation, and interpretation must preserve shared context. Systems should be designed such that understanding is not lost between creators, operators, and analysts.

5. Failure Is a First-Class State

Loss of network connectivity or external infrastructure must not impair core system function. The moments when insight matters most must never coincide with silence.

6. Strategic Failure Handling

When failures occur, I am committed to responding strategically rather than reactively.

This means determining the full scope and impact, identifying true root causes, and implementing coordinated corrective action.

I deliberately avoid "hero engineering"—quick fixes that resolve symptoms while creating secondary failures elsewhere.

7. Change Must Be Cheap

Iteration is not a disruption—it is a requirement. Systems must allow rapid adjustment of behavior without fragility or fear.

8. Validation Is Ethical, Not Optional

Every change introduces risk. Validation preserves trust; without it, insight becomes fiction.

9. Observation Without Agency

Systems document behavior; they do not claim authority over it. Interpretation remains a human responsibility.

10. Longevity Over Optimization

The success of a system is measured by whether it can still tell the truth years later under degraded conditions.

Why These Rules Exist

These principles emerged from direct experience with systems whose failure modes were defined by policy and politics rather than physics.

I have encountered projects where essential capabilities were disabled due to usage thresholds, billing heuristics, deprecations, or strategic shifts by external vendors.

In those moments, the loss was not merely availability — it was trust and continuity of learning.

These rules are a refusal to confuse convenience with resilience.

Closing Statement

My work is designed to last.

Learning should never require permission.

Truth is not a service. It is something that is critical for longevity and sustainability.